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Change Management Plan

Introduction

Change management is the structured way of helping people move from how they work today to how they need to work in future, so that a project's benefits are actually realised (The University of Sydney, 2026). Project management delivers the system; change management makes sure people use it. A system can work perfectly and still fail if staff work around it, distrust it or never learn it.

Project ATLAS (AW3, AW6) adds a control layer between Lyra's app and the AI models it uses. It sends each question to the cheapest model that still meets Lyra's quality bar, reuses answers where it is safe to, and tracks cost and quality continuously. Students will notice little difference, but Lyra's staff will:

- engineers must pass an automatic quality test before releasing any AI change;
- learning designers will help check answer quality; and
- Customer Success will explain cost and quality results to universities.

Academics and university security officers must also be convinced that a 'cheaper model' does not mean worse answers.

We use two models from the lecture. **Kotter's 8 steps** plan the change for the whole company (Kotter, 2012), and **ADKAR** (Awareness, Desire, Knowledge, Ability, Reinforcement) tracks each person's progress (Hiatt, 2006). Figure 1 lines them up with the project timeline in AW4. Before Release 1 goes ahead, the Steering Committee checks that people are ready at Gate 3 (9 February 2027) using four tests: at least 90% of staff understand why ATLAS exists, all on-call engineers and Customer Success staff are trained, on-call engineers have passed a practice drill, and every university security review is complete. A first readiness survey in November 2026 gives the starting point. Table 1 explains the technical terms used in this plan.

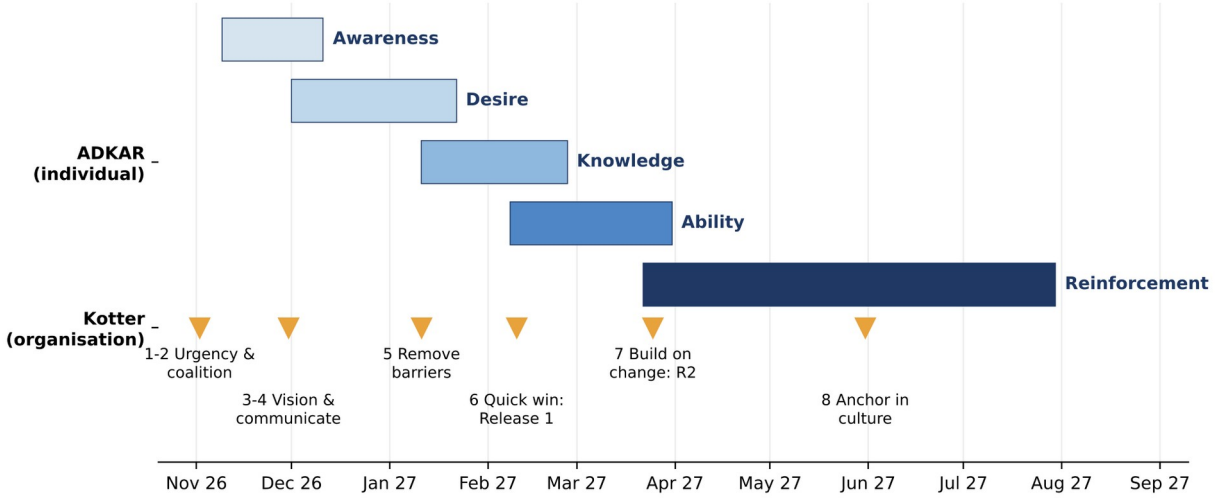


Figure 1. *Change roadmap: ADKAR stages for individuals mapped against Kotter's steps for the organisation, November 2026 to July 2027*

Table 1. *Key terms used in this plan*

Term	Meaning
Gateway	The single entry point that every AI request passes through, so it can be routed, tracked and costed
Quality test (evaluation gate)	An automatic check of answer quality that every AI change must pass before release
Shadow mode / canary release	Running a change silently beside the old one, then switching it on for a small share of users first
Release 1 / Release 2 (R1 / R2)	10 Feb 2027: all requests go through the gateway. 25 Mar 2027: smart routing and caching fully on
Gates 0–4	Decision points where the Steering Committee approves the project to continue (AW4)
Game day	A practice drill in which engineers handle a simulated outage
Cohen's κ (kappa)	A score from 0 to 1 showing how consistently two people grade the same answers

Change vision and objectives

> ***Vision:*** *"Every answer Lyra gives is one we can stand behind, and every dollar we spend producing it is one we can account for. ATLAS lets us grow to every Australian university without trading away the trust that brought them to us."*

The vision puts **trust first and cost second**. This matters because the people most likely to resist – engineers and academics – care most about quality. It also matches the 'quality before cost' rule in AW7. The change has five objectives:

1. **Understanding** – by Gate 2 (29 January 2027), at least 90% of staff can explain why ATLAS exists and what it changes (pulse survey).
2. **New ways of working** – from Release 1 (10 February 2027), every AI change passes the quality test with no shortcuts, and every AI request goes through the gateway.
3. **Skills** – before go-live, all on-call engineers are trained and certified on ATLAS procedures, and both learning designers are trained to grade answers.
4. **University confidence** – all university security reviews are finished before Release 1, and no university formally objects to Release 2.
5. **Lasting change** – by July 2027, the new practices are in company policy and still followed, and at least 75% of staff agree ATLAS "makes my work better or easier".

Change drivers and impact analysis

Drivers of change

Six drivers explain why the change is needed now:

- **Financial (main driver)** – gross margin is about 44% against a 70% target, mainly because each question costs about AUD 0.053 in AI fees (AW3). Growth would make this worse.
- **Competition** – learning management system vendors are adding basic AI features and free tools are everywhere, so Lyra must prove it is both accurate and affordable.
- **Customer expectations** – universities now ask vendors for evidence of AI quality and governance (Lodge et al., 2023).
- **Regulation** – new transparency rules for automated decisions start on 10 December 2026 (Eslaieh, n.d.), and Australia's *Guidance for AI Adoption* sets clear expectations (National Artificial Intelligence Centre [NAIC], 2025).
- **Resilience** – three outages at Lyra's single AI provider in Semester 1, 2026 showed the risk of relying on one supplier.
- **Technology** – cheaper small models and Australian-hosted AI services have only recently made this solution possible (Anthropic, 2026; Choo et al., 2025).

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Impact analysis

Table 2 shows how the change affects each area, from today to after ATLAS.

Table 2. *Change impact analysis by area*

Area	Now	After ATLAS	Impact
Processes	AI changes released on a reviewer's judgement; quality checked by hand before big releases; costs seen only in monthly accounts	Every AI change passes an automatic quality test; changes tried in shadow mode, then on a small share of users; cost per question reviewed weekly	**High**
Technology	App calls one AI provider directly; no tracking or reuse of answers	All requests go through the gateway, which tracks, routes and caches them; cost and quality dashboards	**High** for engineers, **Low** for students
People	Engineers own features; learning designers write content; Customer Success reports usage only	Engineers also own quality and cost results and join a new on-call roster; learning designers grade answers; Customer Success presents quality and cost evidence	**Medium–High**
Culture	'Ship it and see'; the best model is assumed to give the best quality	'Measure, then ship'; quality and cost are everyone's job	**Medium–High**
Universities	Trust Lyra's claims and occasional offline tests	Trust based on regular quality and cost evidence; formal notice of changes	**Medium**

Stakeholder analysis

Table 3 lists each group affected by ATLAS, how it affects them, how much resistance we expect (based on AW5) and the ADKAR stage where they are most likely to get stuck. That last column tells us where to put our effort: a group stuck on *Desire* needs persuading, while a group stuck on *Knowledge* needs training. The two groups to watch most closely are **academics** and **university security officers**, because either can stop adoption or a renewal if they feel a change was hidden from them.

Table 3. *Change impact map for affected stakeholders*

Stakeholder group	Impact on them	Resistance	Likely ADKAR barrier	Engagement strategy
Engineers outside the project team (about 12)	Must use the gateway and pass quality tests; new on-call duties	Medium	Desire: "tests slow us down"	Help set test thresholds; keep tests under 15 minutes; show problems caught; a champion in each squad
Project team engineers	Learn new tools (LiteLLM, Langfuse, Valkey)	Low	Knowledge: new tools	Training budget, pairing, short trial tasks

Stakeholder group	Impact on them	Resistance	Likely ADKAR barrier	Engagement strategy
Learning designers	New role grading answers; extra workload	Low–Medium	Ability: time and tools	Protected 20% of their time; grading tool designed with them; visible credit
Customer Success	Must explain cost and quality data	Low	Knowledge: reading data	Dashboard training; review templates; FAQ
Sales	Can no longer promise "always the best model"	Medium	Desire: losing a selling point	New message: "provably accurate"; approved claims list; reference customers
Product team and Academic Advisory Board	Set the minimum quality level and fairness tests	Low	Awareness of new decision rights	Clear terms of reference; briefing paper
Unit coordinators and academics	Some answers will come from a smaller model	Medium–High	Awareness and Desire: distrust of "cheap AI"	Side-by-side test results; webinar; answer-flag button; partner pilot universities
University security and privacy officers	Must review the architecture change	Medium	Awareness: need full disclosure	Formal change notice; updated security pack; briefing calls
Students	Possibly faster answers; new transparency notice	Low	Awareness	Plain-language notice in the app and a help article
Student associations and accessibility units	Want assurance ATLAS is fair to all students, including international, EAL and disabled students	Low–Medium	Awareness: cannot yet see fairness results	Fairness results before R2; accessible (WCAG 2.2) plain-English notices; feedback session
Executives and Board	Sponsor and fund the change; accept new governance	Low	Reinforcement after go-live	Gate reports, benefits dashboard, visible support

Communication plan

This plan builds on the communication plan in AW5 but focuses on three change messages for each group: **why** it is changing, **what is in it for them**, and **what they need to do**. Kotter (2012) warns that leaders must repeat the vision far more often than feels necessary, so the CEO and CTO lead the staff messages. Every channel also lets people reply, so concerns surface early.

Table 4. *Change communication plan*

Stakeholder group	Objective	Methods	Frequency	Owner
All Lyra staff	Explain why; share the vision	CEO all-hands launch; monthly demo; Notion change hub; Slack #atlas	Launch 16 Nov 2026, then monthly	CEO and CTO

Stakeholder group	Objective	Methods	Frequency	Owner
Engineering (all squads)	Build support and skills for quality tests and the gateway	Engineering guild sessions; written standards; pairing; sprint demos	Fortnightly, Dec 2026 – Mar 2027	Applied AI Lead; Engineering Manager
Learning designers and Academic Advisory Board	Involve them in defining quality	Co-design workshops; grading training; advisory board paper	Fortnightly; board quarterly	CPO
Customer Success and Sales	Tell the new value story accurately	Workshop; FAQ; approved claims list; review role-play	Before R1 and R2	Head of Customer Success; Product Owner
University security and privacy officers	Disclose the change; get sign-off	Formal notice letter; briefing call; security pack	Proposed 30 days before R1 and R2, subject to contract	Head of Security
University academics	Show that quality is protected	Webinar; one-page guide; LMS announcement template; side-by-side results	Before Semester 1; mid-semester	Customer Success with learning designers
Students	Be transparent without causing alarm	In-app notice; help article; privacy policy update	At R2	Product Owner; Privacy Officer
Student associations and accessibility units	Show ATLAS is fair and accessible	Briefing note; fairness results; feedback session	Before R2; after benefits review	CPO

Training and capacity Building

Training needs come from the gap between today's roles and the future roles in Table 2, checked with a short skills self-assessment in November 2026. Training mixes short formal sessions with learning on the job, because new habits stick best when they are used straight away. This builds the *Knowledge* and *Ability* stages of ADKAR.

Table 5. *Training and capacity-building plan*

Audience	Training need	Delivery method	Timing	Measure of success
Project team engineers	Set up and run the new tools (LiteLLM, Langfuse, Valkey, router)	Vendor guides; trial tasks; pair programming; 2-day LLMOps course	Nov 2026 – Jan 2027	Sprint goals met; code-review checklist passed

Audience	Training need	Delivery method	Timing	Measure of success
All engineers	Using the gateway; writing and reading quality tests; safe rollout and rollback	90-minute workshop and recording; practice drills	Before Gate 2 (29 Jan)	100% attend; quiz ≥ 80%
On-call engineers	Handling ATLAS incidents: emergency switch-off and provider failover	Game day: practice outage in a test environment	Before R1 (10 Feb)	100% certified; drill issue fixed in < 15 min
Learning designers and advisory board reviewers	Grading answers consistently with the quality rubric	Calibration workshops on a shared set of answers	Nov 2026, then monthly	Grading agreement (κ) ≥ 0.7
Customer Success and Sales	Reading university dashboards; explaining routing honestly; approved claims	Workshop, role-play, FAQ	Before R1 and R2	Role-play passed; no unapproved claims in spot checks
Unit coordinators and academics	Understanding routing and how to flag a doubtful answer	30-minute webinar and one-page guide	Before Semester 1, 2027	Attendance; flag button used
Executives and Steering Committee	Reading the cost and quality dashboard; their decision rights	30-minute briefing	Before Gate 2	Dashboard used in decisions

Support. People will have a Notion change hub with guides, recordings and FAQs; a #atlas-help Slack channel answered within four business hours; an ATLAS champion in each squad and in Customer Success; twice-weekly office hours with the Applied AI Lead during February–March 2027; and four weeks of extra support (hypercare) after Release 2. The training budget is AUD 9,000 (AW6).

Resistance Management

Resistance is normal and often useful, because it tells us what people are worried about. We therefore treat it as feedback to understand, not opposition to defeat. Table 6 lists the main sources, why they arise, how we respond and who is responsible.

Table 6. *Sources of resistance and response strategies*

Source	Who	Why it happens	How we respond	Owner
Loss of freedom or speed	Engineers	Quality tests and change approvals feel like red tape	Engineers help set test thresholds; tests run in under 15 minutes; routine changes pre-approved; celebrate problems caught	Applied AI Lead

Source	Who	Why it happens	How we respond	Owner
Fear of "cheap AI"	Academics, learning designers, some engineers	Belief that a smaller model gives worse answers	Show side-by-side test results first; publish the minimum quality level; automatic rollback; answer-flag button	CPO
Extra workload	Learning designers, Customer Success	New tasks on top of current work	Protected time (AW4, AW6); tools designed with them; drop lower-value tasks	Delivery Lead
Fear of looking incompetent	Engineers new to the tools; Customer Success	Unfamiliar tools and data	Supportive training, pairing and practice drills; 'no blame' culture	People & Culture Lead
Losing a selling point	Sales	"We always use the best model" was an easy message	New message: "provably accurate at a fair price"; reference customers; approved claims	Head of Sales & Partnerships
Distrust of motives	Staff and universities	Suspicion that ATLAS is only cost-cutting or leads to job cuts	CEO states publicly that ATLAS is not about cutting jobs; open reporting of benefits	CEO
Caution about any change	University security teams	Every change is a risk and extra review work	Early notice; complete security pack; one contact person; flexible briefing times	Head of Security

We expect a short dip in confidence and productivity around Release 1, as the Kübler-Ross change curve predicts (The University of Sydney, 2026), so training, office hours and champions are concentrated in February–March 2027.

We track resistance through pulse surveys, retrospectives, champion reports, requests to skip quality tests and answer-flag numbers. When a group stays stuck, ADKAR shows where. For example, if engineers understand the tests but still try to skip them, the problem is *Desire*, not *Knowledge*, so the fix is incentives and peer influence rather than more training (Hiatt, 2006). Individual concerns are handled privately by the person's manager.

Cultural Considerations

Company Culture before the change

Cameron and Quinn's (2011) **Competing Values Framework** describes four culture types:

- **Clan** – collaborative and people-focused, like a family.
- **Adhocracy** – entrepreneurial, innovative and willing to take risks.

- **Market** – focused on results and competition.
- **Hierarchy** – controlled, process-driven and focused on efficiency.

Lyra today is mainly an **Adhocracy with strong Clan features**. As a one-year-old start-up, its identity is built on creating something new. Engineers, learning designers and former academics work side by side in the same squads (Clan). Ideas are shipped quickly, and success is judged by what the product can do rather than how efficiently it runs (Adhocracy). There are few formal processes: changes are released on a reviewer's judgement and costs are checked monthly.

Lyra does value evidence – 'claims are settled by evaluation data' (AW2) – but in practice it tests answer quality only occasionally and offline. In Schein's (2010) terms, evidence is a value Lyra talks about but does not yet live by.

Desired company culture after the change

Our target is a **'disciplined adhocracy'**. Lyra stays mainly innovative (Adhocracy) but adds:

- more **Market** – clear accountability for results such as cost per question and gross margin; and
- a few **Hierarchy** practices – quality tests, change approval and audit trails.

The Clan strengths stay, through engineers and learning designers sharing responsibility for quality.

We chose this target for two reasons. First, Lyra's advantage over large competitors is its speed, so becoming a mainly Hierarchy culture would remove what makes a 34-person company competitive. Second, growing to eight universities while keeping their trust means quality and cost must be measured and owned, not assumed. In one sentence: **from 'ship it and see' to 'measure it, then ship it fast'.**

Bridging the gap

Six actions move Lyra from its current culture to the target, each with an owner:

- **Lead by example** – the CTO and Applied AI Lead put their own changes through the quality tests first and share the results, including failures (CTO).
- **Make the new way the easy way** – quality tests run automatically, quickly and with clear feedback, so following the process is easier than avoiding it (Engineering Manager).

- **Reward new behaviour** – sprint reviews celebrate a problem caught or a saving made without losing quality, and quality work counts in performance reviews (People & Culture Lead).
- **Build habits** – a weekly 'cost and quality minute' at stand-up and a shared dashboard on the office screen (Applied AI Lead).
- **Keep freedom where it matters** – squads decide *how* to meet quality and cost targets; only the evidence required is fixed (CTO).
- **Make it permanent** – update the AI Policy, engineering handbook and job descriptions so the culture lasts beyond the project, which is Kotter's step 8 (People & Culture Lead).

Success metrics and monitoring

We measure adoption with two kinds of indicator. **Leading** indicators show whether people are changing, for example training completed. **Lagging** indicators show whether the change delivered results, for example staff saying ATLAS makes their work easier. Table 7 sets a baseline, target, owner and escalation trigger for each KPI; these match the project KPIs in AW12.

Table 7. *Change adoption KPIs*

KPI (type)	Baseline → target	Source and frequency	Owner	If off track (trigger)
Staff who understand why ATLAS exists (Leading)	Measured Nov 2026 → ≥ 90% by Gate 2	Pulse survey, monthly	People & Culture Lead	< 75% → targeted messages
Training completed, by group (Leading)	0% → 100% of on-call and Customer Success before R1	Learning records, weekly	People & Culture Lead	< 100% at Gate 3 → R1 held
On-call engineers certified by game day (Leading)	0% → 100% before R1	Drill results	Engineering Manager	Any uncertified 1 week before R1 → L2
AI requests through the gateway (Adoption)	0% → 100% from R1	Gateway logs, real time	Engineering Manager	Any direct request → L2
AI changes passing quality tests with no skips (Adoption)	≈ 0% → 100%	Release logs, weekly	Applied AI Lead	Any unrecorded skip → L2
Learning-designer grading agreement, κ (Quality)	Measured Nov 2026 → ≥ 0.7	Calibration, monthly	CPO	< 0.6 → recalibrate
University security reviews done before R1 (External)	0 → 100%	Customer Success tracker	Head of Security	Any outstanding 1 week before R1 → L3
Answers flagged by academics per 10,000 (Lagging)	Set at R1 → no increase after R2	In-app flags, weekly	Product Owner	+25% in a week → L2

KPI (type)	Baseline → target	Source and frequency	Owner	If off track (trigger)
Staff agreeing "ATLAS makes my work better or easier" (Lagging)	Measured after R1 → ≥ 75% by Jul 2027	Pulse survey	CTO	< 60% → change plan review
Practices still followed 3 months after closure (Sustainment)	Level at Gate 4 → 100% test coverage; weekly cost review held	Post-implementation review	Steering Committee	Any lapse → Steering Committee action

L2 = Project Board (response within 48 hours); L3 = Steering Committee (within 5 working days), as set out in AW7.

Feedback mechanisms. We collect feedback through monthly two-question pulse surveys, sprint retrospectives, the #atlas-feedback Slack channel, fortnightly champion check-ins, the answer-flag button for academics and students, and university business reviews. Each month the Delivery Lead sends a short 'you said, we did' update so people can see their feedback changing the plan.

Continuous improvement. The plan improves itself through a Plan–Do–Check–Act cycle (Deming, 1986), the same loop behind the ITIL continual improvement model in AW12. At each stage gate the Steering Committee reviews the adoption KPIs alongside technical readiness. If a KPI is off track, we use ADKAR to find the cause, adjust our action (for example targeted training, a clearer message or a new champion) and measure again. After the project closes, reinforcement continues until the July 2027 benefits review, when the new practices are written into policy and handed over to normal management (Kotter, 2012).

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